

POLICY, POLITICS AND GOVERNANCE FOUNDATION • MOOKERJEE FELLOWSHIP

Karnataka

A regional reading of society, geography, politics and economy :
from the Halmidi inscription (c. 450 CE) to the eve of the 2028 Vidhan Sabha

August 2026

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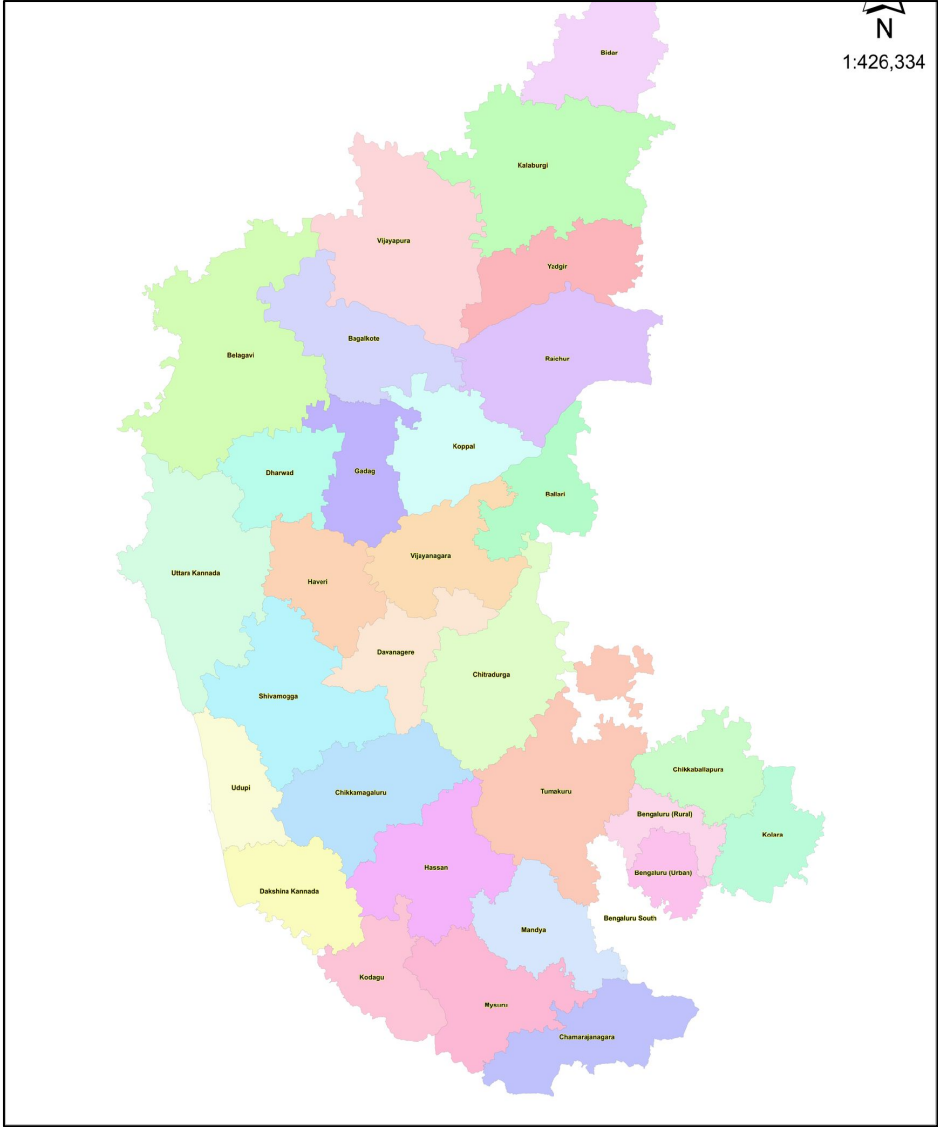
V. Elections & the Way Forward

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Karnataka

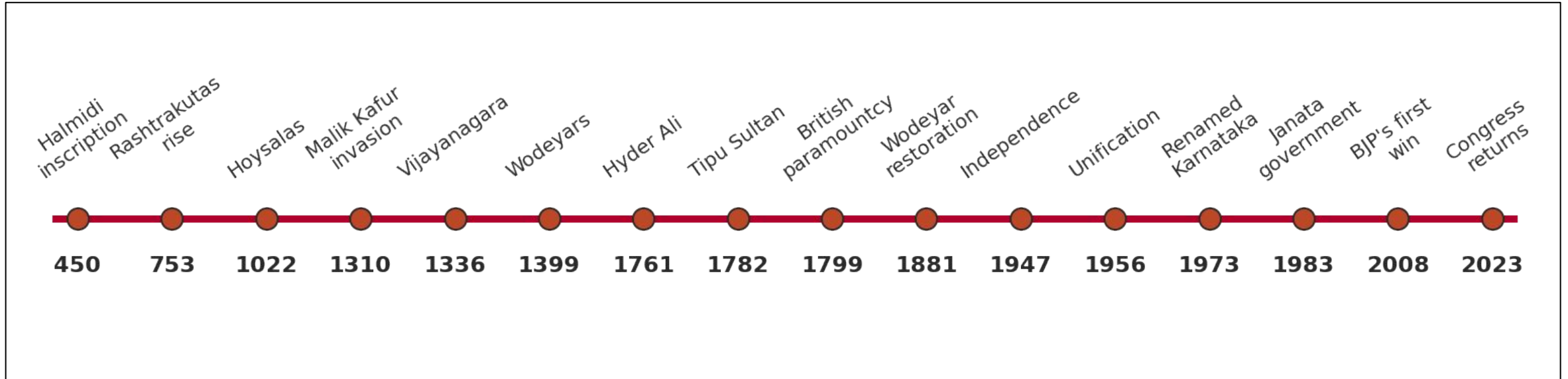
KEY FACTS

- **Location & Borders:** Located in south-west India, bordered by the Arabian Sea, Goa, Maharashtra, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, and Kerala.
- **Size & Rank:** It is India's 6th largest state by land area and 8th most populous.
- **Capital City:** Bengaluru is the capital, widely recognized as the "Silicon Valley of India"
- **State Animal & Tree:** The Indian Elephant is the state animal, and the fragrant Sandalwood is the state tree.
- **Formation Day:** November 1st is celebrated annually across the region as Kannada Rajyotsava (Foundation Day).
- **Karu + nāḍu :** The Kannada compound is usually read as “elevated land”, the Deccan plateau as self-description.



Districts of Karnataka

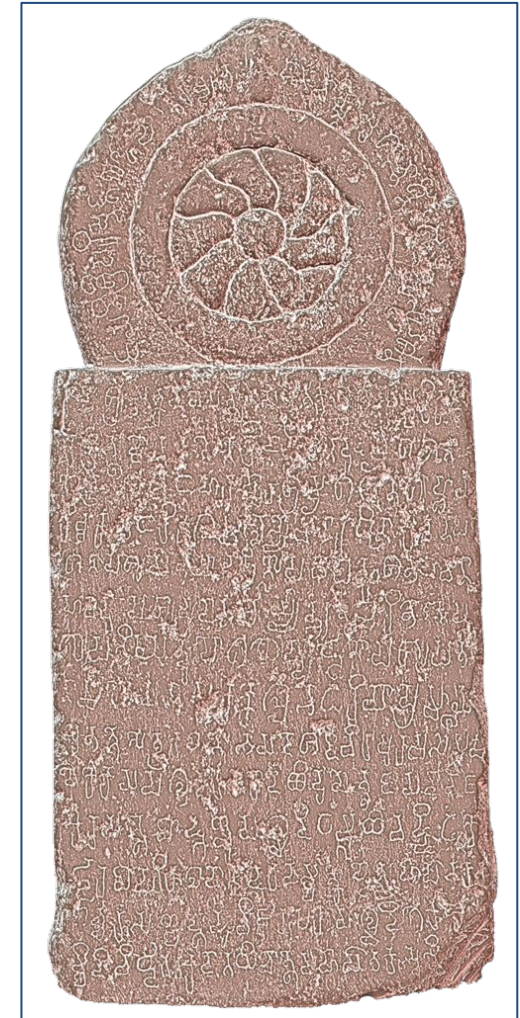
Timeline — Halmidi to Karnataka (450–2023)



Reading the arc: a 1,500-year continuum of indigenous dynasties (Kadambas → Chalukyas → Rashtrakutas → Hoysalas → Vijayanagara → Wodeyars), an interlude of Deccan sultanates and Mysore's Hyder–Tipu, then the administrative merger of five fragments into a single Kannada state in 1956, renamed Karnataka in 1973.

The First Kannada : The Halmidi Inscription

- 450 CE, Halmidi village (Hassan district).
- The oldest known Kannada inscription , issued under the Kadamba dynasty.
- Proves Kannada was an administrative & literary language over 1,500 years ago.
- Kannada later became the first language other than Sanskrit to receive classical status (2008).
- A founding document of Kannada identity.



Halmidi Inscription

Chalukyas · Rashtrakutas · Hoysalas



Badami Chalukyas (6th–8th C)

Pattadakal, Aihole & Badami, 'cradle of temple architecture'



Rashtrakutas (8th–10th C)

Manyakheta empire, in photo entry of Malkhed fort.



Hoysalas (10th–14th C)

Belur, Halebidu & Somanathapura — star-shaped, lathe-turned shrines

The Deccan Sultanates : Malik Kafur's shadow



Gol Gumbaz

- 1310–11 : Malik Kafur (Alauddin Khalji's general) raids the Deccan, sacking the Hoysala capital & Devagiri.
- Bahmani Sultanate (1347) ,the first Deccan sultanate, later splintering into five.
- Adil Shahis of Bijapur builders of the Gol Gumbaz (1626); Barid Shahis of Bidar.
- A north–south fault line that still echoes in the Hyderabad-Karnataka region's backwardness.
- Kannada identity persisted despite sultanate rule in the north.

Vijayanagara : Empire & the Hampi Chariot



Hampi Chariot

- 1336 :founded by Harihara & Bukka (Sangama dynasty) on the Tungabhadra.
- Krishnadevaraya (1509–29) : The empire's golden age; a Kannada-Telugu cultural synthesis.
- 1565 : defeat at Talikota ends Vijayanagara's sway; Hampi is sacked.
- Hampi's ruins (UNESCO) : The stone chariot & musical pillars of the Vittala temple.
- Its collapse opened space for the Wodeyars, sultans and, later, Hyder Ali.

Wodeyar I : A Dynasty Under Vijayanagara's Wing

1399 :Yaduraya Wodeyar establishes the Wodeyar line at Mysuru, granted the region as Vijayanagara feudatories.

- For nearly two centuries the Wodeyars rule Mysuru as loyal vassals of Vijayanagara.
- The dynasty provides continuity , the same family still presides over Mysuru today.
- Mysuru emerges as a stable agrarian principality in the south.
- Set against the concurrent Vijayanagara empire.

Wodeyar II : Asserting Independence

After Talikota, the Wodeyars step out of Vijayanagara's shadow and build an independent Mysuru kingdom.

- Raja Wodeyar (1578–1617) captures Srirangapatna and shifts the seat of power.
- Chikka Devaraja Wodeyar (1673–1704) : Administrative, revenue & territorial consolidation.
- Kantheerava Narasaraja I : A warrior king who minted the celebrated 'Kantheerava fanam' coinage.
- A Hindu principality coexisting with the Bijapur & Mysore sultanates around it.

Hyder Ali & Tipu Sultan : Mysore Resists



Gumbaz

- Hyder Ali (1761–82) : Soldier-king who made Mysore a modern military power.
- Tipu Sultan (1782–99) : Rockets, trade & diplomacy.
- Four Anglo-Mysore Wars (1767–1799) against the British East India Company.
- 1799 : Fall of Srirangapatna; Tipu dies defending the fort.
- The British restore the Wodeyars as a subsidiary princely state.

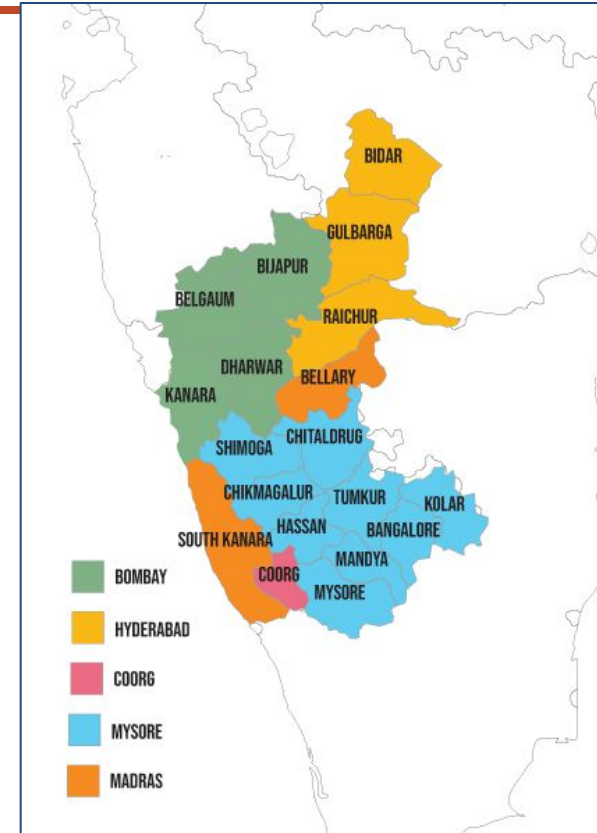
Wodeyar III : Restoration & the Model State



Mysore Palace

- 1881 'Rendition' : Chamaraja Wadiyar X regains the reins of administration.
- Krishnaraja Wadiyar IV (1894–1940) : A progressive 'model state': hydro-power (Shivanasamudra), universities, industry.
- Mysuru pioneered modern administration, education & industrialisation in princely India.

Independence — One language, five Fragments



Making of Karnataka



Flag of Karnataka

- Kannada speakers were split across Mysore State, Bombay Presidency (Bombay-Karnataka), Hyderabad State (Hyderabad-Karnataka), Madras Presidency & Coorg.
- This fragmentation fuelled the Karnataka Ekikarana (unification) movement.
- Aluru Venkata Rao , 'Karnataka Kulapurohita' , led the cultural argument for one state.
- Linguistic states became national policy after 1956 , Karnataka was among the first big mergers.

One Karnataka : The States Reorganisation

1 November 1956 : the States Reorganisation Act merges the Kannada-speaking territories into a unified Mysore State.

- Mysore State absorbed Bombay-Karnataka, Hyderabad-Karnataka, parts of Madras (incl. Kolar) and Coorg.
- 1 November is celebrated as Karnataka Rajyotsava (state formation day).
- Unification consolidated Kannada identity and created the modern state's six-region geography.
- Regional imbalances inherited from the merger remain a live political issue to this day.

Mysore to Karnataka : The Renaming

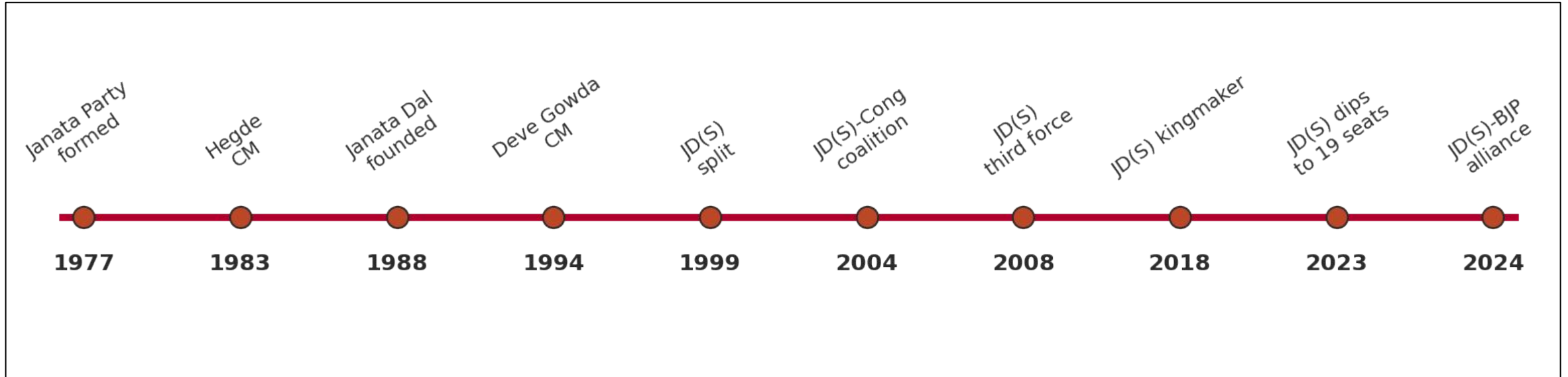
1973 : Under Chief Minister D. Devaraj Urs, Mysore State is officially renamed 'Karnataka'.

- The name change recognised that the state was more than the old Mysuru kingdom , it encompassed all Kannada regions.
- Devaraj Urs (1972–77) , a social-justice reformer: land reforms & backward-class uplift.
- Symbolic completion of the Ekikarana movement's cultural project.

The Congress era

- 1952–1983 : Congress dominated Karnataka's first three decades.
- Chief ministers : K. Chengalaraya Reddy, Kengal Hanumanthaiah S. Nijalingappa, D. Devaraj Urs.
- Devaraj Urs (1972–77) : land reforms & 'backward classes' mobilisation that reshaped Karnataka's social coalition.
- 1977–78 : President's under the Emergency's anti-Congress wave.
- The Congress era laid the caste-based social coalitions that still structure Karnataka politics.
- SR Bommai case (1994)

Evolution of the Janata Dal : Timeline



- The Janata Parivar gave Karnataka the Hegde and Deve Gowda governments; its 1999 split created the JD(S), now a Vokkaliga-anchored third force.

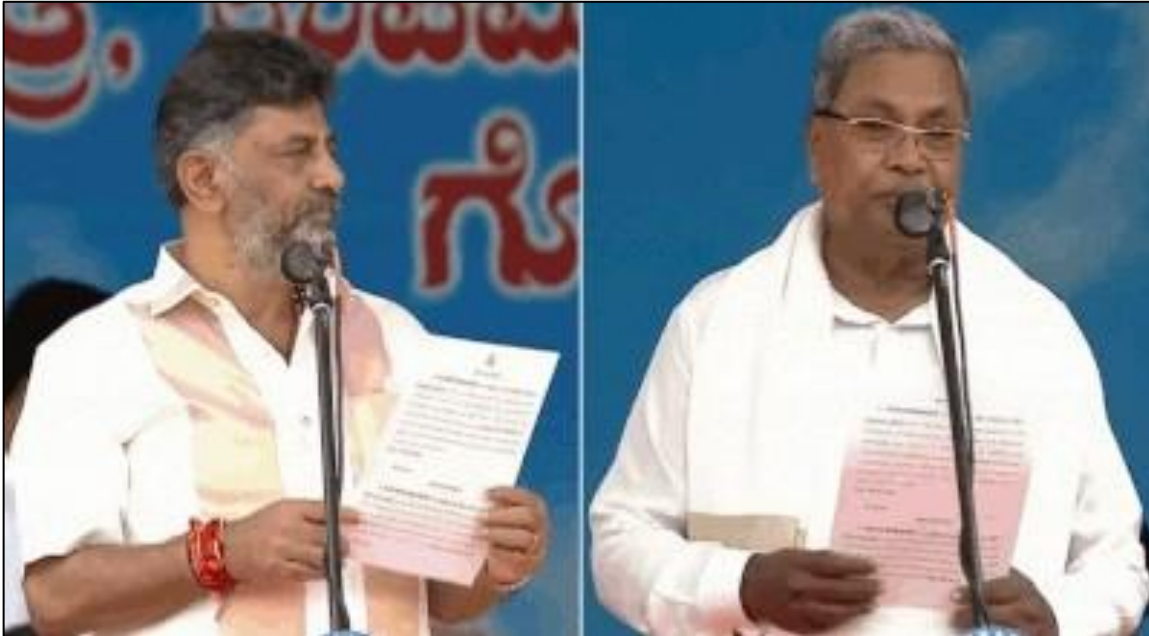
Siddaramaiah & the Caste Survey

- The Socio-Economic & Education Survey ('caste census') was launched in 2015 during Siddaramaiah's first term , ₹160 cr, 1.6 lakh surveyors, 1.35 crore households.
- Submitted 2024–25 by the Backward Classes Commission (Hegde, then Naik).
- Headline findings : Muslims ~14% (largest community), Veerashaiva-Lingayats ~11%, Vokkaligas ~10%, Kurubas ~8%; backward classes ≈ 70%.
- Recommendation : Raise backward-class reservation from 32% to ~51%.
- Politically explosive : Dominant Lingayat & Vokkaliga communities are wary; a defining issue heading into 2028.

The Rise of the BJP in Karnataka

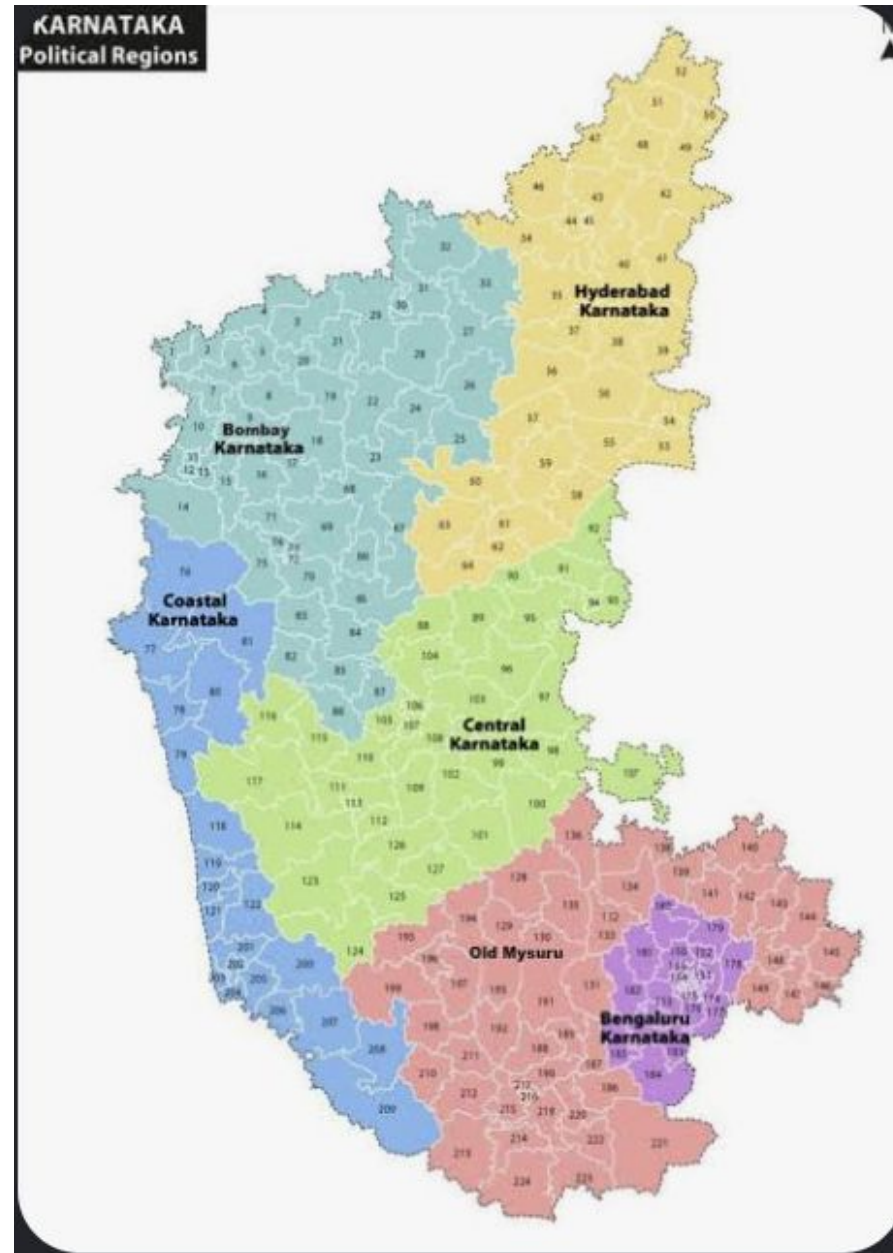
- 2008 : Yediyurappa leads the BJP to its first southern state government.
- 2012 : Yediyurappa left the BJP.
- 2014 & 2019 : Modi wave : BJP swept 17, then 25 of 28 Lok Sabha seats (51.4% vote share in 2019).
- 2018 : Single-largest party (104 seats) but a JD(S)–Congress coalition kept it out; it toppled the government in 2019.
- 2019–23 : Yediyurappa and then Basavaraj Bommai lead the government.
- Core base : Lingayats + urban middle class + Hindutva vote; lost 2023 to Congress's welfare pitch.

Siddaramaiah–DKS : A dual power structure



- 2023 : Congress wins 135/224 seats on the five-guarantee promise.
- Siddaramaiah (CM) : Kuruba/AHINDA base, the state's fiscal manager.
- D.K. Shivakumar (DyCM & KPCC president) : Vokkaliga muscle & organisational grip.
- Dual leadership balances the AHINDA and Vokkaliga blocs : and carries built-in succession tension.
- D.K. Shivakumar from June 2026 is the CM of Karnataka

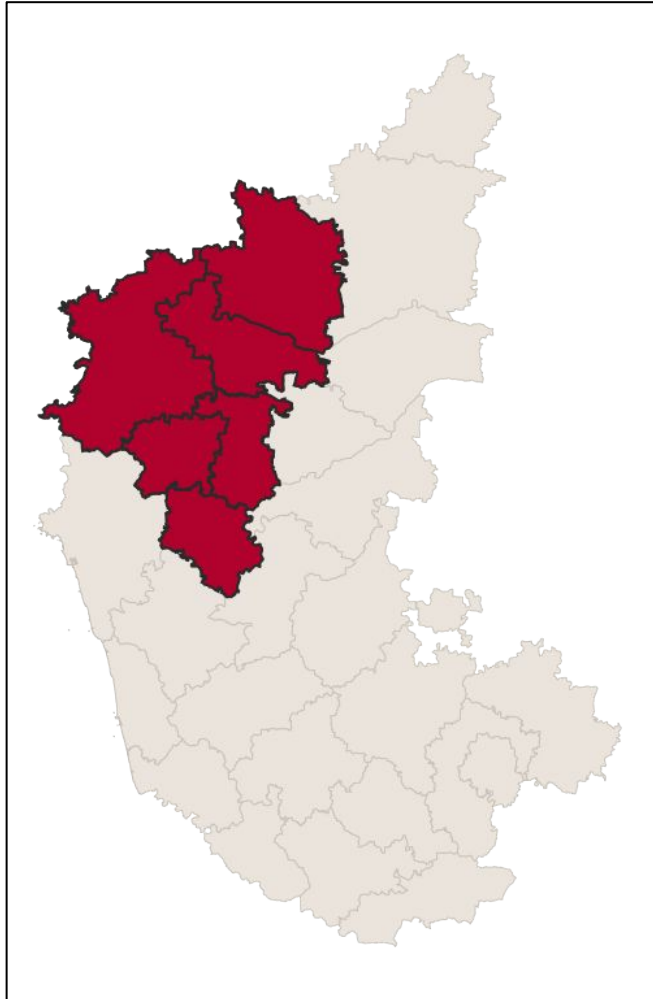
6 Regions of Karnataka



Physical Map of Karnataka



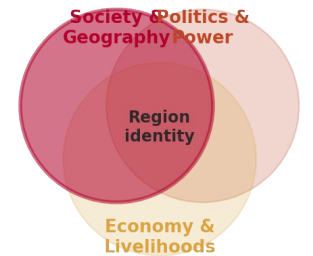
Society & Geography



BOMBAY KARNATAKA

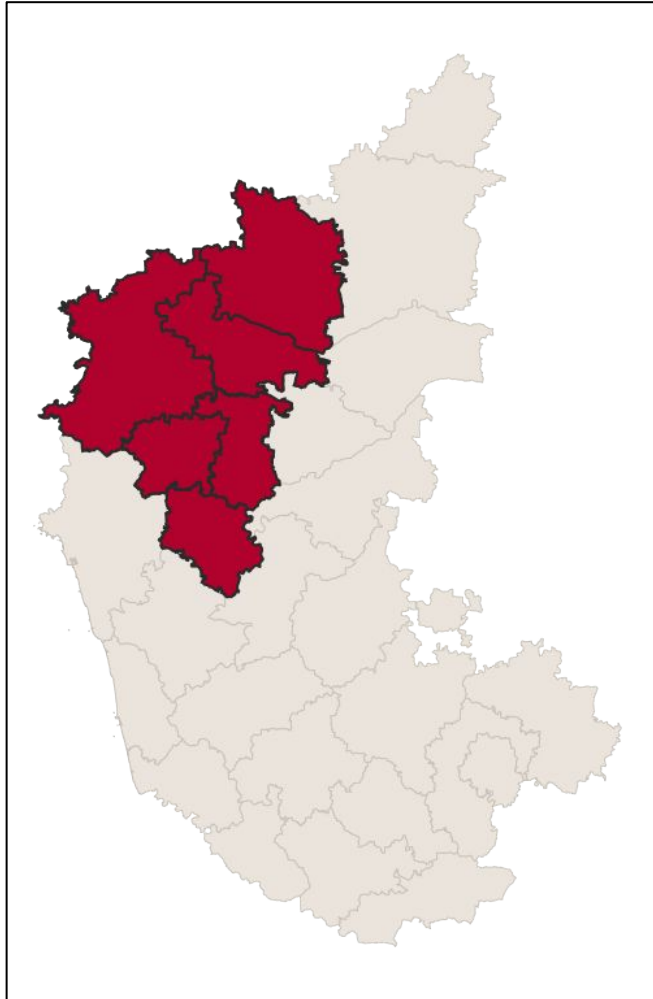
The Lingayat heartland & a contested borderland

- Veerashaiva-Lingayat majority : the region's defining social bloc
- Districts: Belagavi, Dharwad, Vijayapura, Bagalkot, Gadag, Haveri
- Belagavi–Maharashtra border dispute running since 1957 (Maharashtra Ekikaran Samiti)
- Strong 'North Karnataka' identity; historic demand for development parity with the south



Overlapping structures

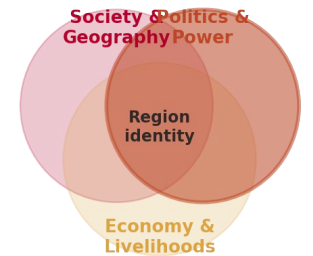
Politics



BOMBAY KARNATAKA

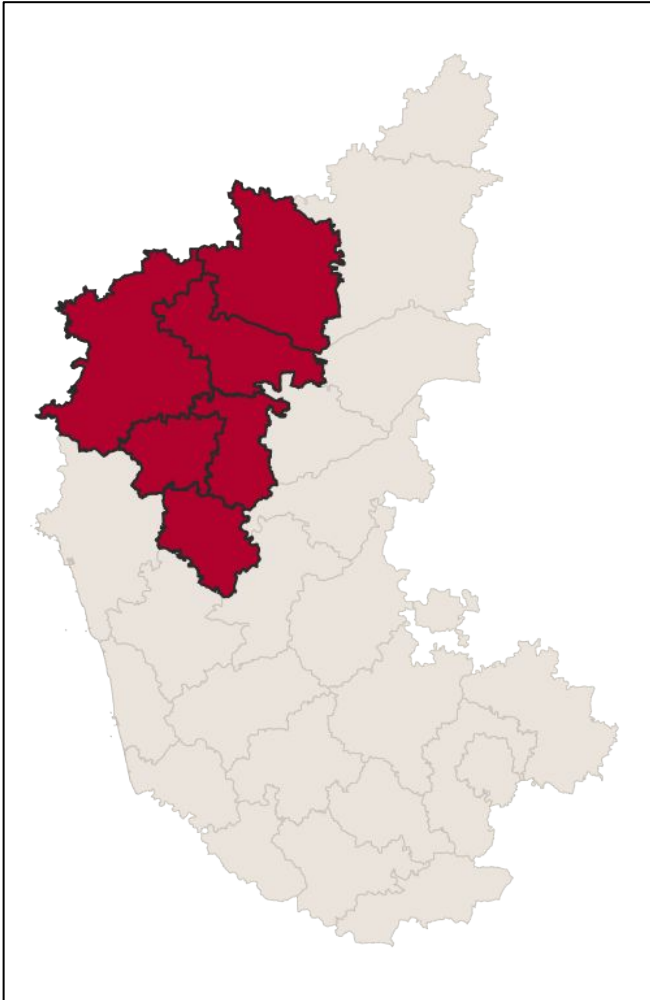
The Lingayat heartland & a contested borderland

- BJP stronghold, anchored in decades of Lingayat consolidation
- Leaders: Jagadish Shettar, Pralhad Joshi (Dharwad)
- Border agitation keeps the MES a live force in Belagavi
- Mahadayi river dispute
- Congress broke through in 2023 ; 44 of 62 seats across Kittur+Central Karnataka



Overlapping structures

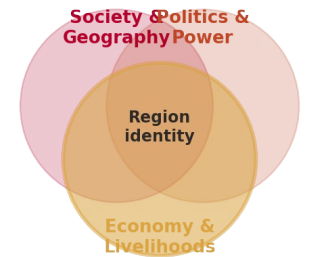
Economics



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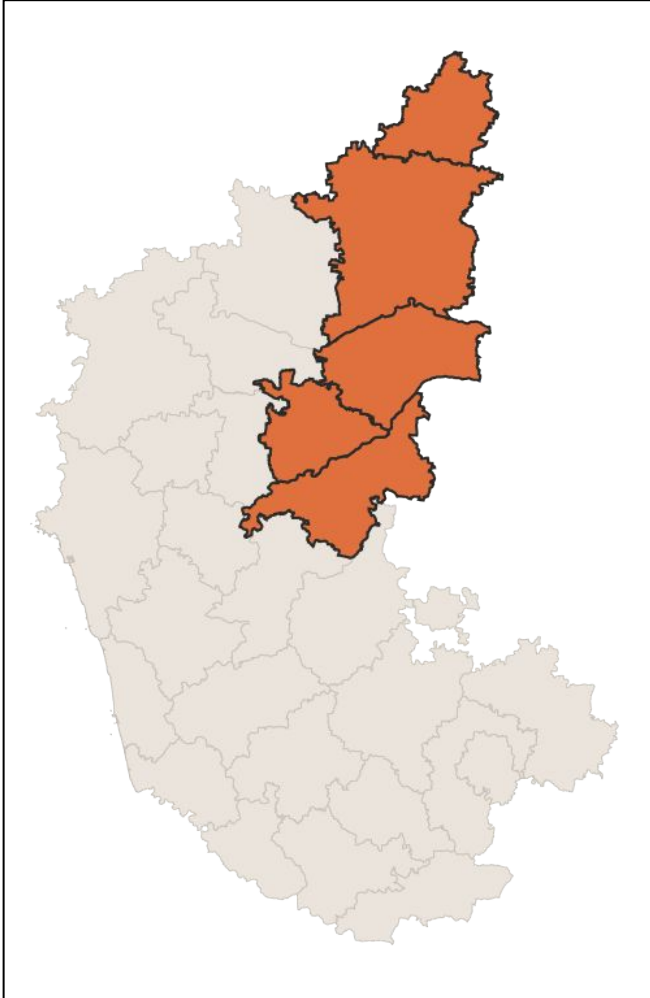
The Lingayat heartland & a contested borderland

- Sugarcane, jowar & horticulture; Krishna-basin irrigation
- Hubballi–Dharwad twin-city industrial & railway hub
- Belagavi: foundry, hydraulics & auto-parts cluster
- Chronic water stress & a widening north–south development gap



Overlapping structures

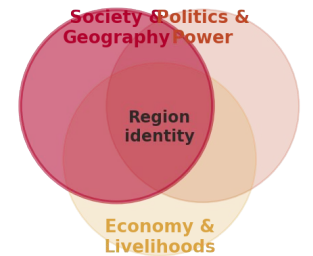
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HYDERABAD KARNATAKA

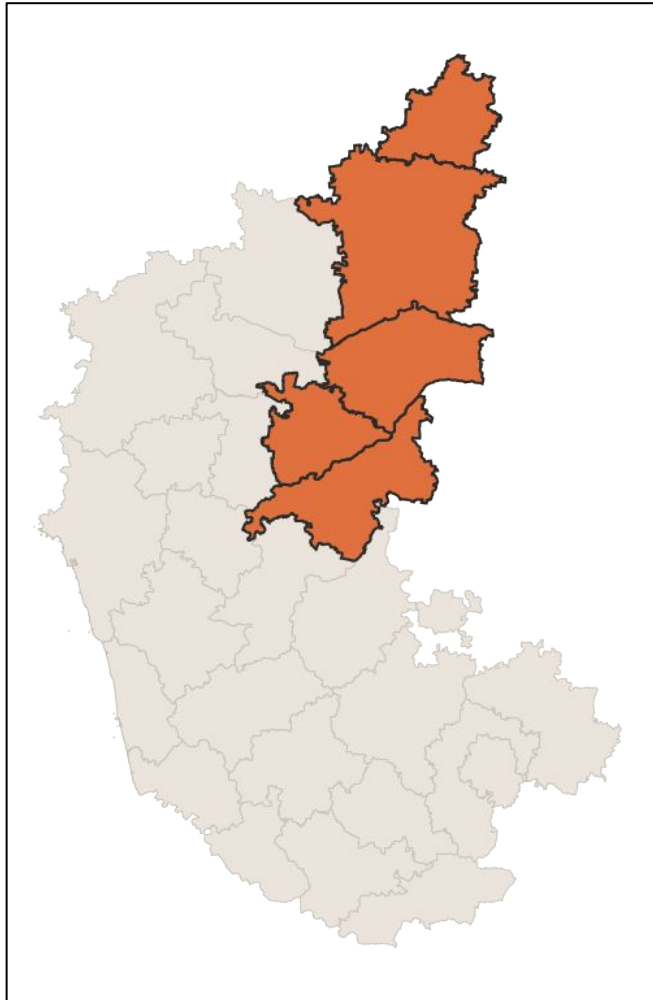
The most backward region — now Congress's new frontier

- Districts: Kalaburagi, Bidar, Raichur, Koppal, Ballari, Yadgir
- High SC/ST & minority share; the state's lowest HDI belt
- Article 371J (2012) : Special status & development provisions
- Nizam-era lag; officially renamed 'Kalyana Karnataka' in 2019



Overlapping structures

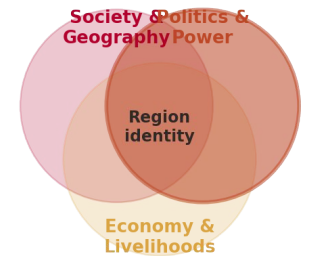
Politics



HYDERABAD KARNATAKA

The most backward region , now Congress's new frontier

- Congress swept all five Lok Sabha seats here in 2024
- Kharge family base (Kalaburagi); Siddaramaiah's AHINDA mobilisation
- Ballari was once BJP's mining-money bastion (
- Five-guarantee welfare resonates most strongly in this region



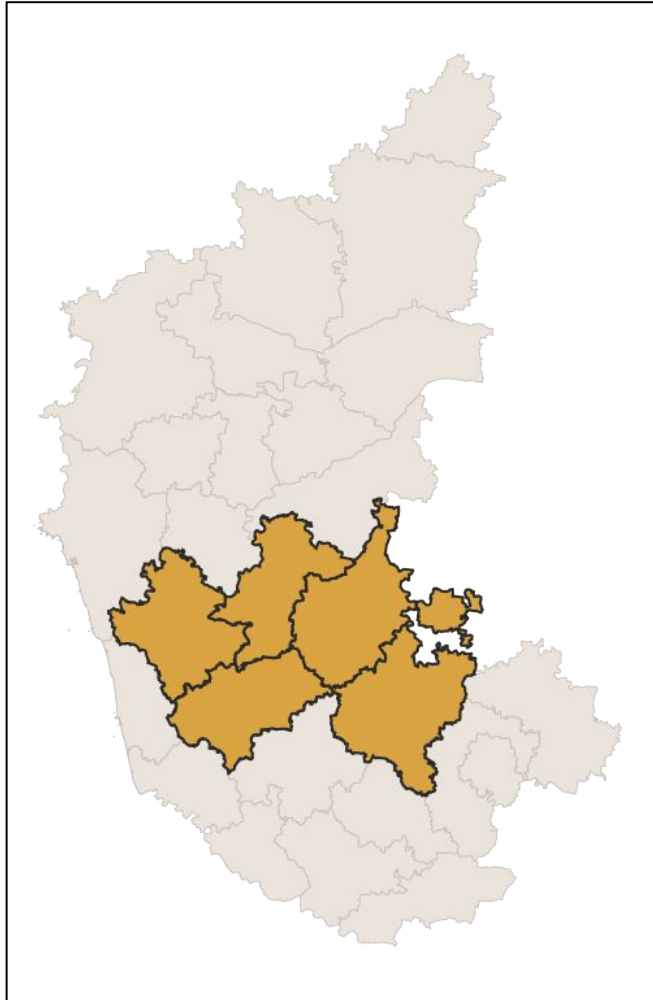
Overlapping structures



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PPGF · Mookerjee Fellowship Regional deep-dive · Hyderabad Karnataka

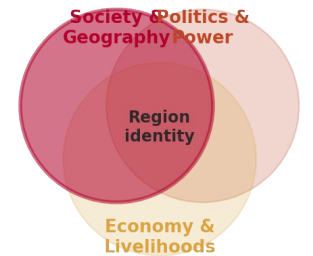
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CENTRAL KARNATAKA

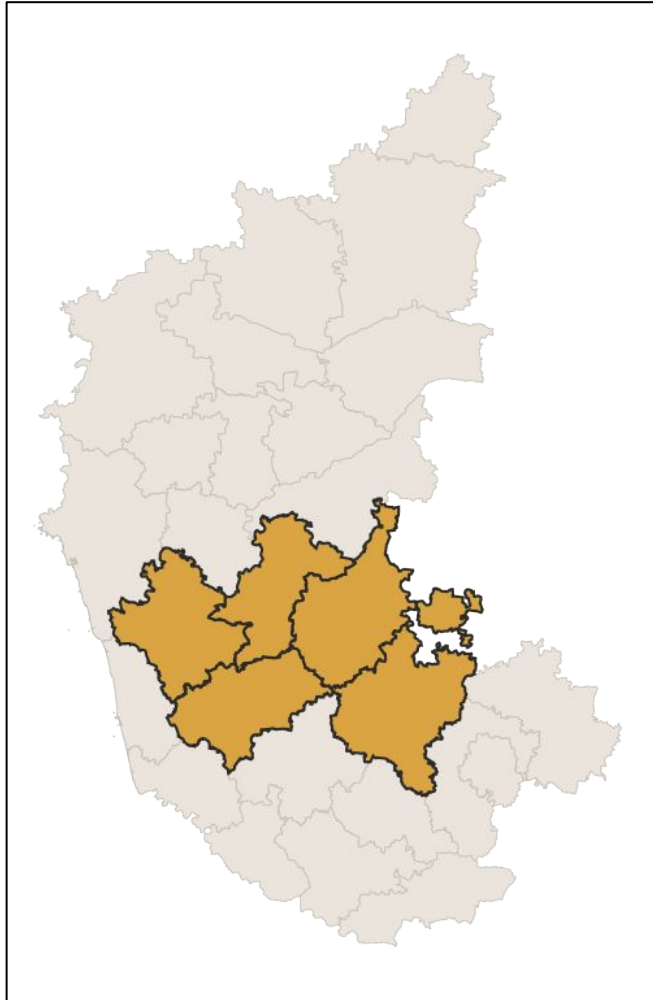
Lingayat–Malnad core & Yediyurappa's home turf

- Districts: Shivamogga, Davanagere, Chitradurga, Tumakuru, Chikkamagaluru
- Lingayat plus substantial SC/ST and Kuruba presence
- Malnad (hills) vs Bayaluseeme (plains) ecological & social divide
- Shivamogga is the political cradle of the Yediyurappa family



Overlapping structures

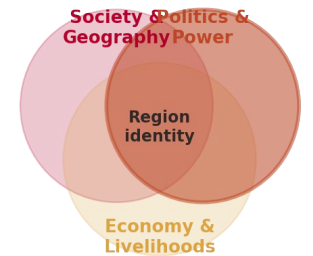
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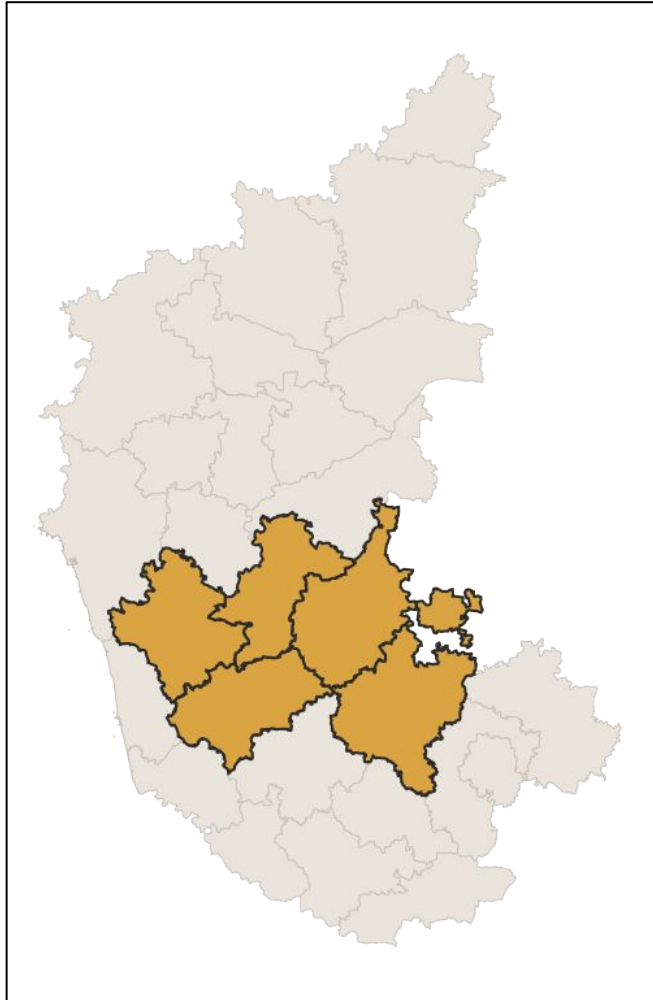
Lingayat–Malnad core & Yediyurappa's home turf

- BJP's Lingayat fortress; Yediyurappa family dominance (Shikaripura)
- Carries the legacy of Janata Dal & Ramakrishna Hegde
- Congress holds Tumakuru and contests Davanagere
- Electoral arithmetic pivots on Lingayat vs AHINDA mobilisation



Overlapping structures

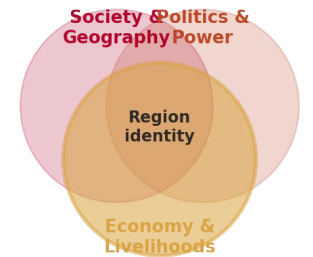
Economics



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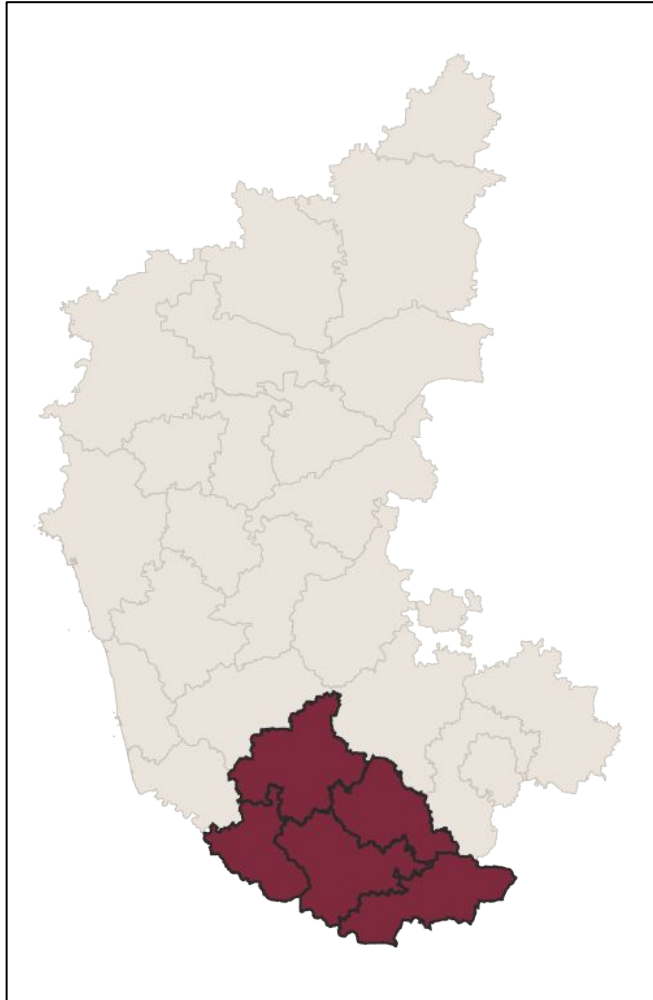
Lingayat–Malnad core & Yedyurappa's home turf

- Arecanut, coconut & paddy; Chikkamagaluru coffee estates
- Davanagere textiles & Chitradurga iron-ore mining
- New Shivamogga airport; Malnad & Jog-falls tourism
- Cauvery & Tungabhadra canal irrigation backbone



Overlapping structures

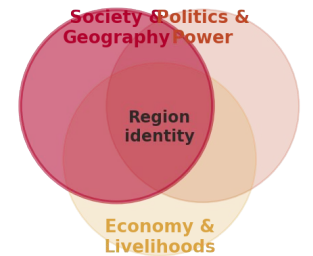
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OLD MYSORE

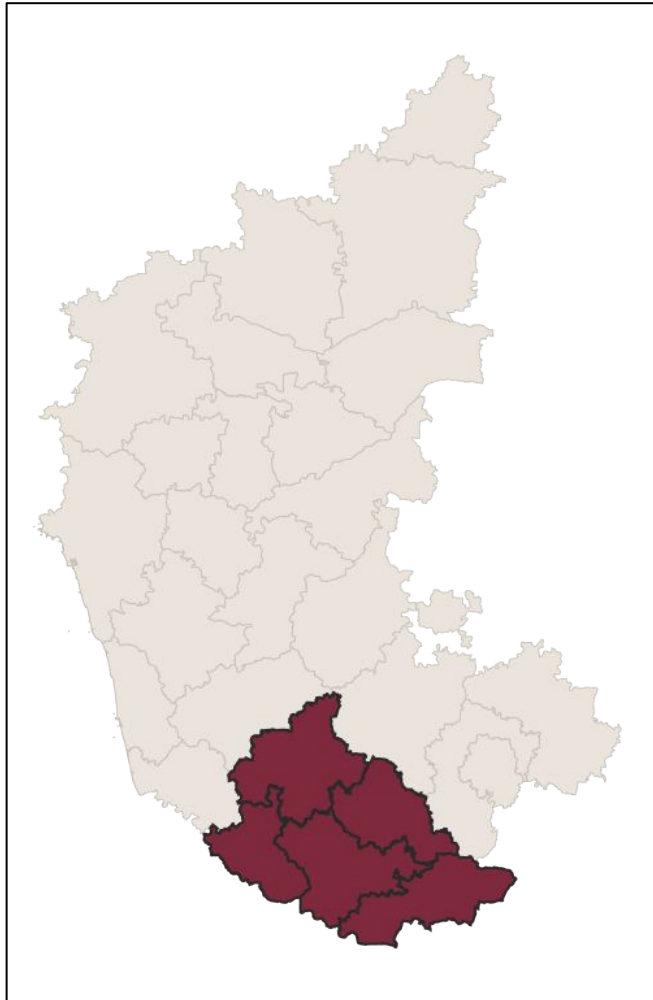
The Vokkaliga heartland & the JD(S) base

- Districts: Mysuru, Mandya, Hassan, Chamarajanagar, Kodagu
- Vokkaliga dominance across the Cauvery-irrigated fertile core
- Deep cultural identity , Mysuru Dasara & royal heritage
- Kodagu (Coorg) retains a distinct Kodava identity



Overlapping structures

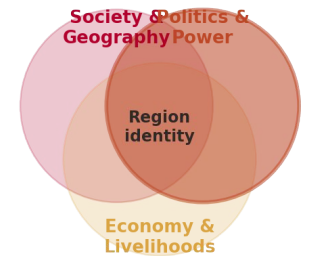
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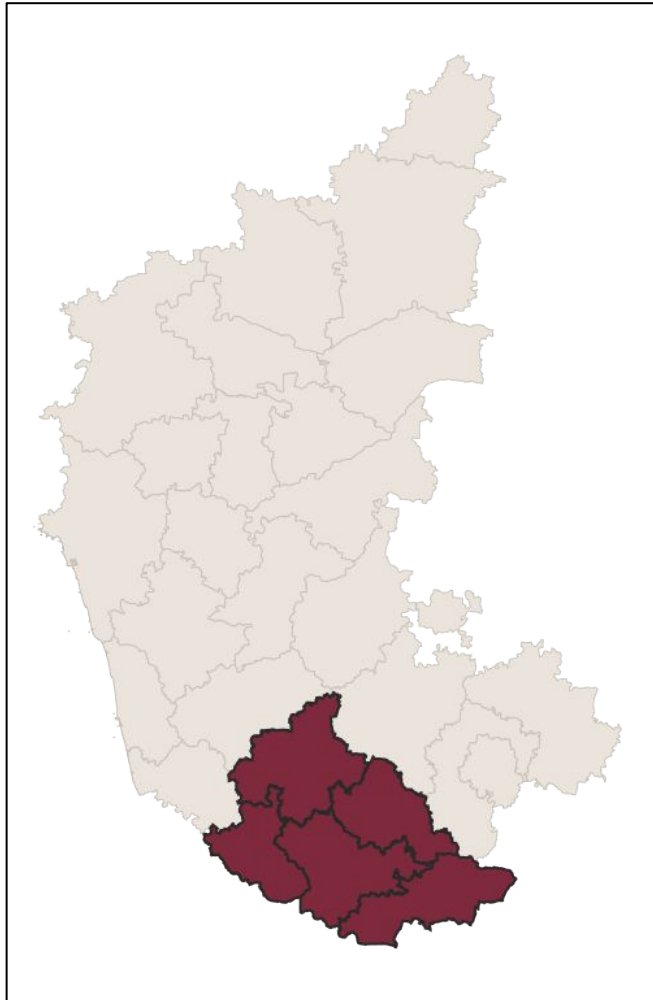
The Vokkaliga heartland & the JD(S) base

- JD(S) base of the Deve Gowda–Kumaraswamy family (Vokkaliga)
- Congress revival in 2023 : won most of South Karnataka
- Cauvery water-sharing politics against Tamil Nadu
- Kasargod dispute with Keralam.
- Mysuru royal family remains a symbol of regional pride



Overlapping structures

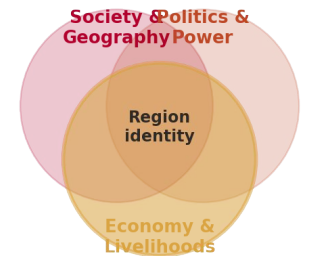
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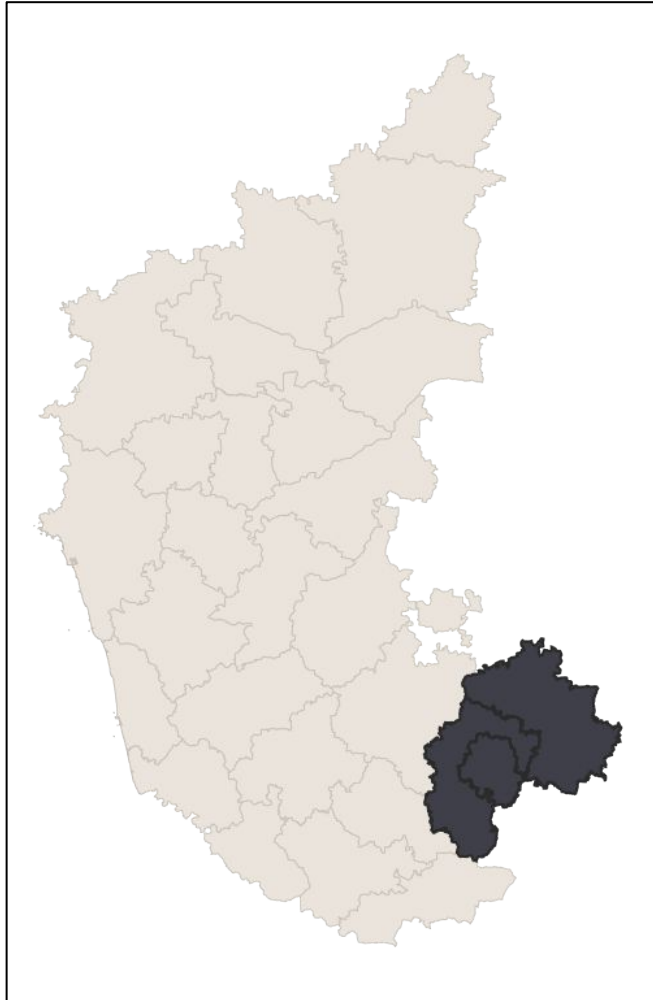
The Vokkaliga heartland & the JD(S) base

- Paddy, sugarcane & ragi under the Cauvery command area
- Mysuru: manufacturing, IT & tourism (palace, Dasara, zoo)
- Kodagu coffee & pepper estate economy
- High farm indebtedness & recurring water disputes



Overlapping structures

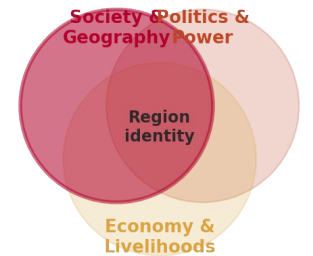
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BANGALORE

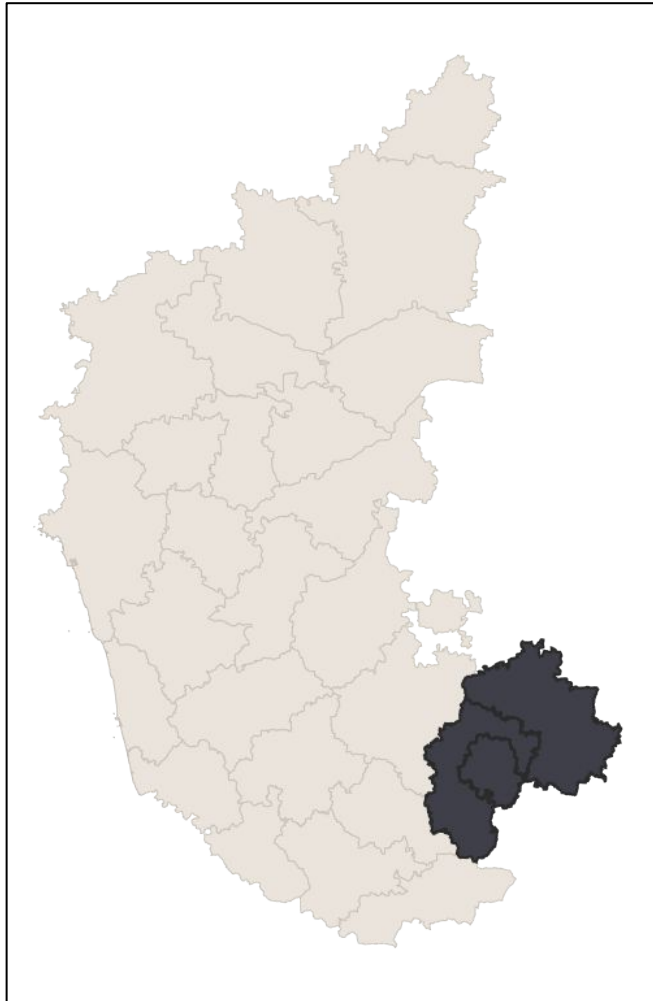
The IT engine & urban electoral battleground

- Bengaluru Urban/Rural, Kolar (with Chikkaballapur & Ramanagara)
- India's IT capital , massive migration & a cosmopolitan mix
- Urban sprawl, gridlock traffic, water & infrastructure stress
- A sharp rural–urban fault line runs through the metro region



Overlapping structures

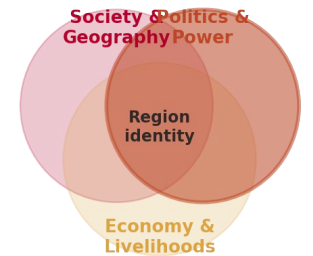
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BANGALORE

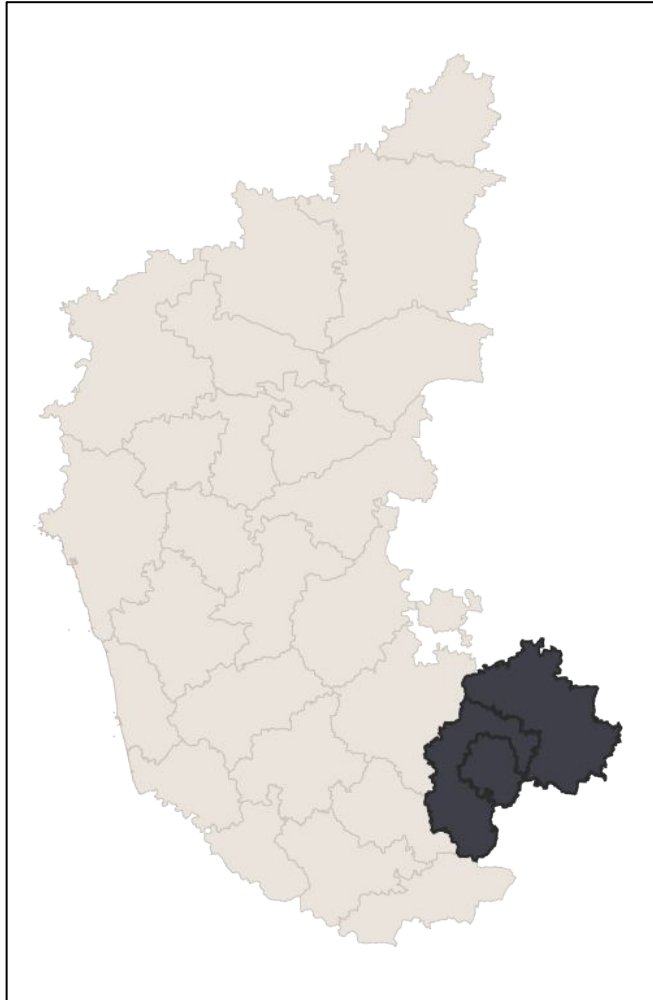
The IT engine & urban electoral battleground

- BJP swept all three Bengaluru Lok Sabha seats in 2024
- Urban middle-class tilt to BJP; Congress competitive in rural
- DK Shivakumar's home base (Kanakapura / Bengaluru Rural)
- Lower urban turnout; class-and-service politics vs caste



Overlapping structures

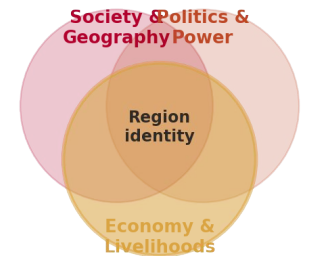
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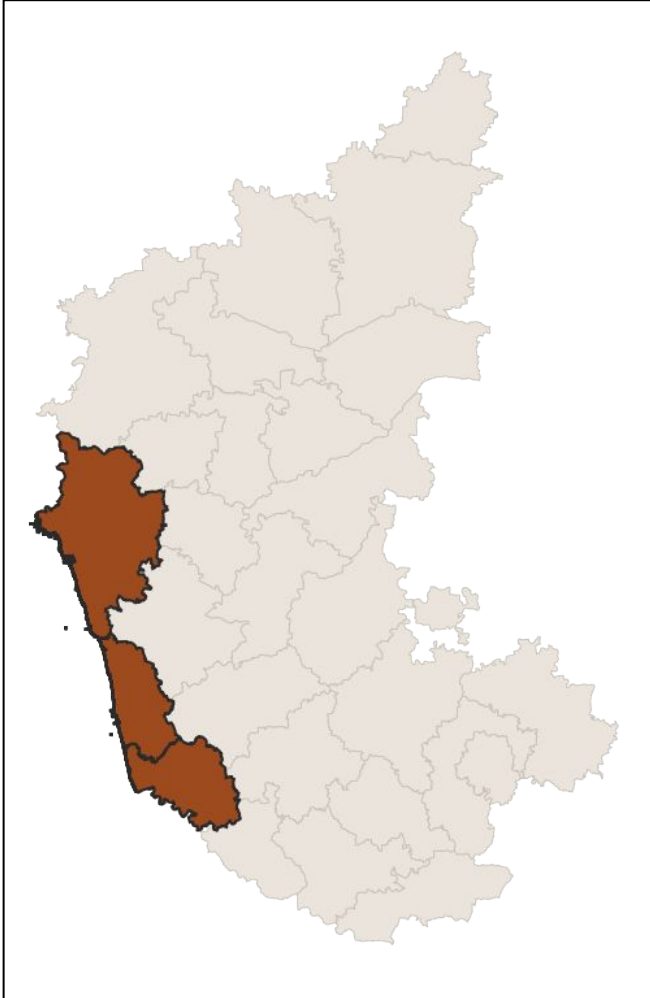
The IT engine & urban electoral battleground

- IT/ITES, global capability centres & a startup ecosystem
- ~40% of state GSDP; aerospace, biotech & fintech clusters
- Premium real estate & a deep consumption economy
- Infrastructure debt & congestion as binding growth constraints



Overlapping structures

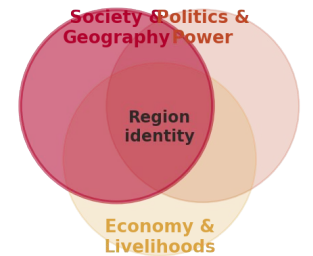
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COASTAL KARNATAKA

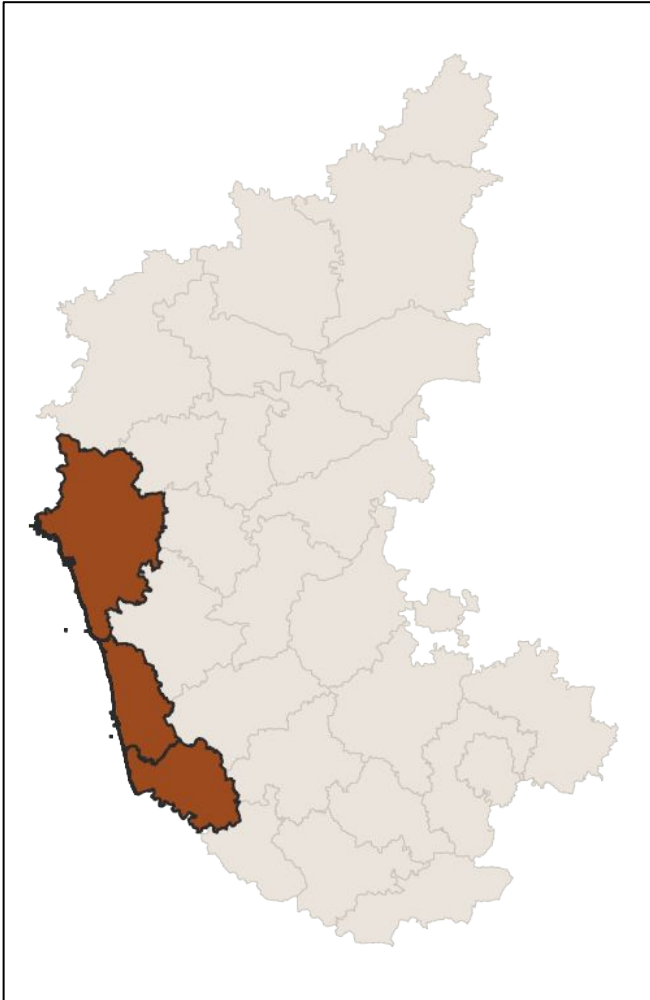
High-development coast & Hindutva stronghold

- Districts: Dakshina Kannada, Udupi, Uttara Kannada
- High literacy, HDI & a strong banking/education culture
- Tulu, Konkani & Beary , a multi-religious, multi-lingual mix
- Tulu identity & periodic statehood assertions



Overlapping structures

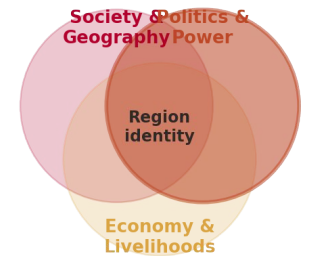
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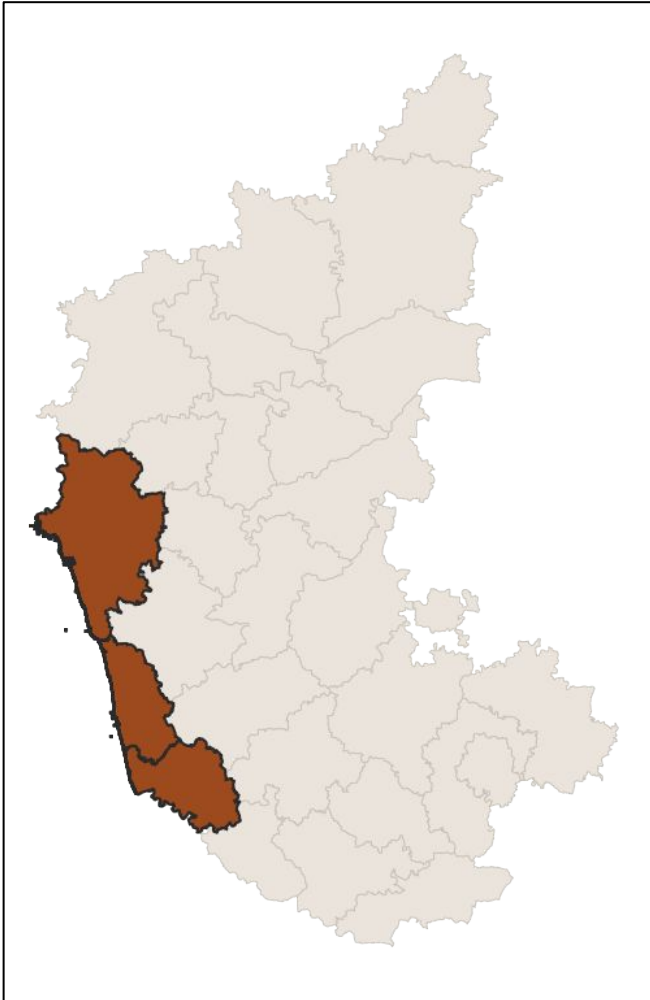
High-development coast & Hindutva stronghold

- BJP swept all three coastal Lok Sabha seats in 2024 by record margins
- Dense RSS–Hindutva base; communal polarisation
- Congress confined to a handful of seats; coastal MLAs influential
- Mathas & religious institutions overlap with politics



Overlapping structures

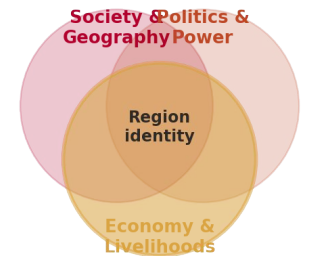
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COASTAL KARNATAKA

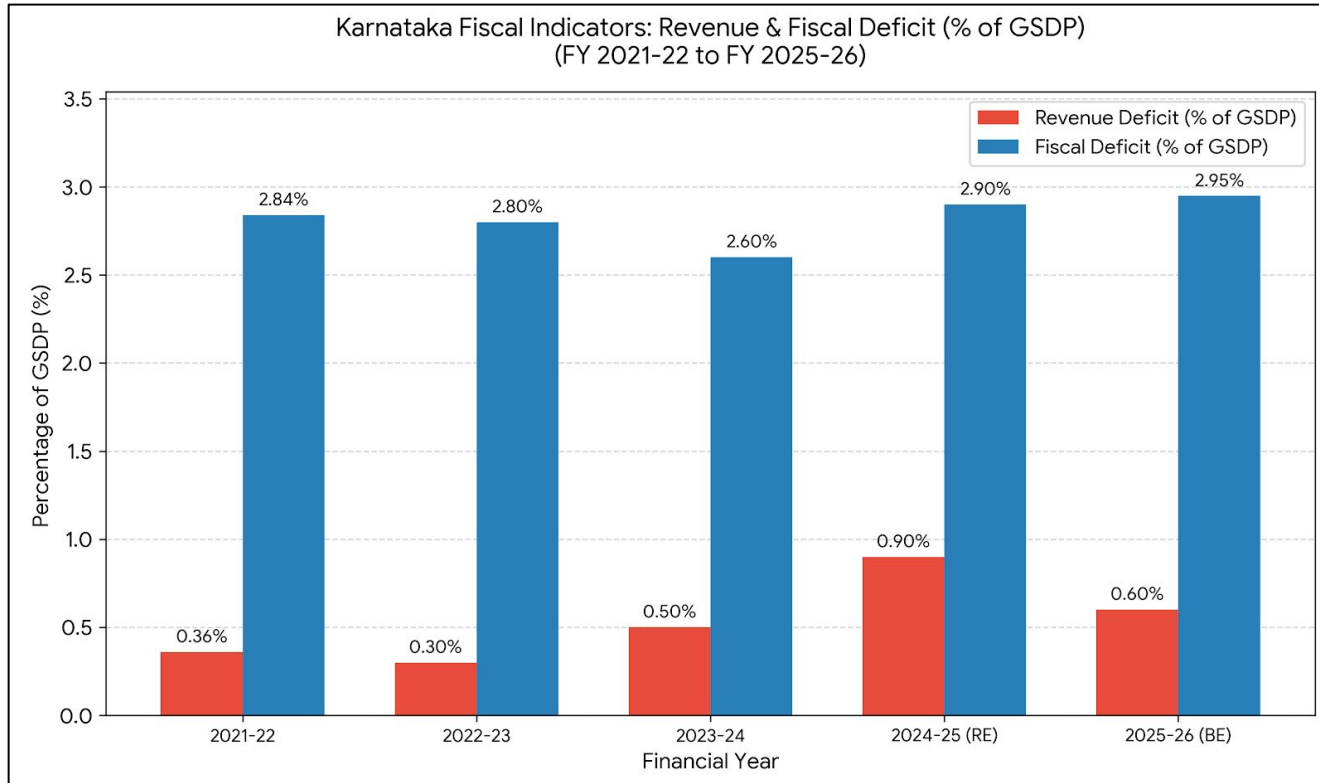
High-development coast & Hindutva stronghold

- New Mangalore & Karwar ports; SEZs, refineries & petrochemicals
- Banking & education hubs (Manipal, Mangaluru)
- Tourism, fisheries, cashew & coastal industries
- High remittance & service-sector economy



Overlapping structures

The State's Fiscal Health

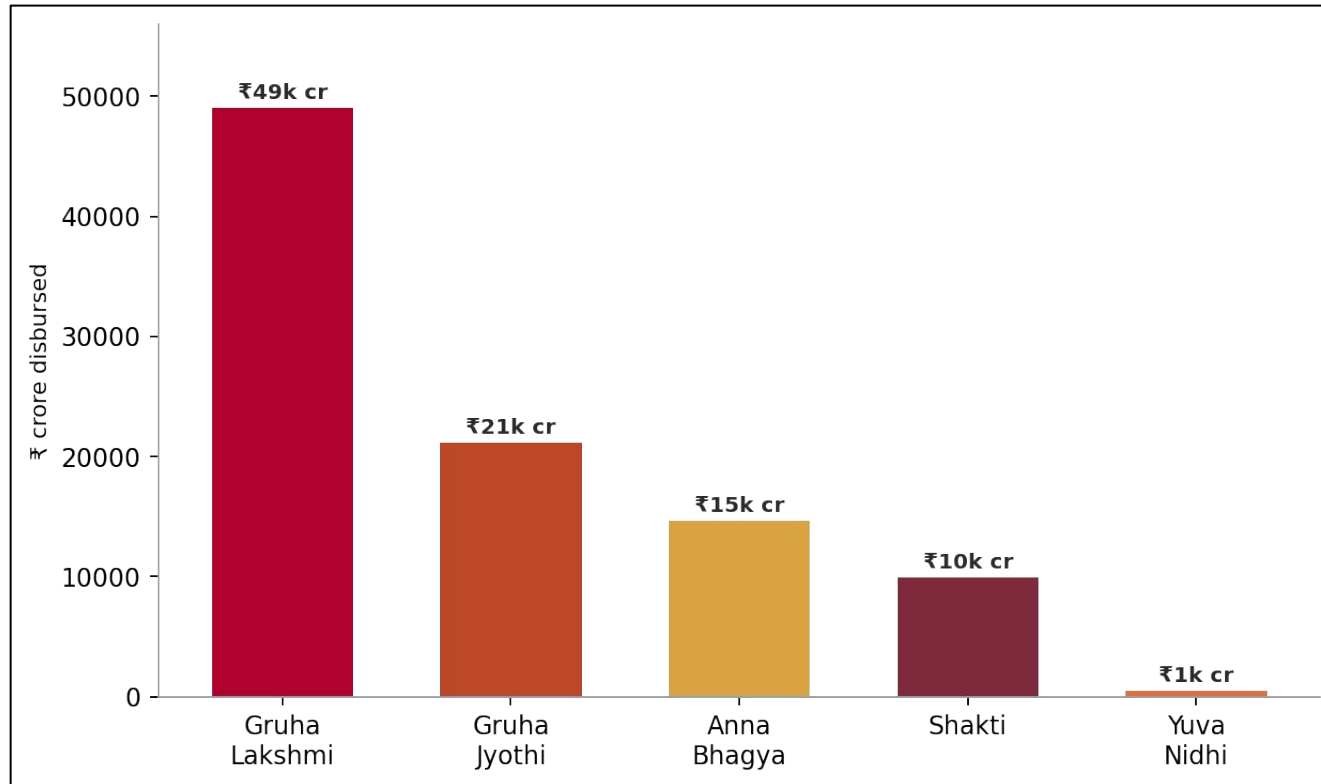


- GSDP growing at 8.1% : among India's fastest large states.
- Outstanding liabilities $\approx$ 25% of GSDP (₹8.2 lakh crore by 2025-26).
- Fiscal deficit $\sim$ 2.97% of GSDP (2024-25 actuals) : within the 3% FRBM ceiling.
- Revenue deficit narrowing to $\sim$ 0.7% of GSDP.
- Own tax revenue strong (₹1.77 lakh crore i.e 6.7% of GSDP) but guarantee schemes raise revenue expenditure.

Fiscal Stress Points

- Guarantee schemes cost ~₹52,500 crore in 2024-25 alone i.e ~15% of revenue expenditure.
- Debt is nearing the FRBM sustainability threshold (~25% of GSDP).
- Revenue deficit persists because borrowing is financing welfare commitments.
- Central devolution & GST compensation disputes strain state finances.
- Trade-off is welfare entitlements vs capital (infrastructure) spending.

Flagship policies : The Five Guarantees



- Gruha Lakshmi : ₹2,000/month to 1.23+ crore women heads of family.
- Gruha Jyothi : free power up to 200 units (1.61 crore households).
- Anna Bhagya : 10 kg rice/month (4.43 crore beneficiaries).
- Shakti : Free bus travel for women (500 crore+ tickets issued).
- Yuva Nidhi : ₹3,000/₹1,500 monthly to unemployed graduates/diploma holders.

Costs & critiques of the guarantees

- Fiscal sustainability : Near-universal entitlements are hard to roll back.
- Targeting & leakage : Universal design vs means-testing debates.
- Crowding-out : Capital expenditure & core services compete with subsidies.
- Electoral lock-in : Guarantees have become a political floor no party can remove.
- Yet measurable impact : Higher women's mobility, nutrition & savings reported in surveys.

Health

Antenatal care: 82.4% of mothers received an antenatal check-up in the first trimester, compared with 71.0% in NFHS-5.

Four or more ANC visits: 84.5% of mothers received at least four antenatal check-ups, compared with 70.9% previously.

Institutional births: 98.7% of births occurred in health institutions, compared with 97.0% in NFHS-5.

Skilled birth attendance: 96.6% of births were attended by skilled health personnel, compared with 93.8% in NFHS-5.

Postnatal care: 93.6% of mothers received postnatal care within two days of delivery, compared with 87.4% in NFHS-5.

Full immunisation: 90.2% of children aged 12–23 months were fully vaccinated, compared with 84.3% in NFHS-5.

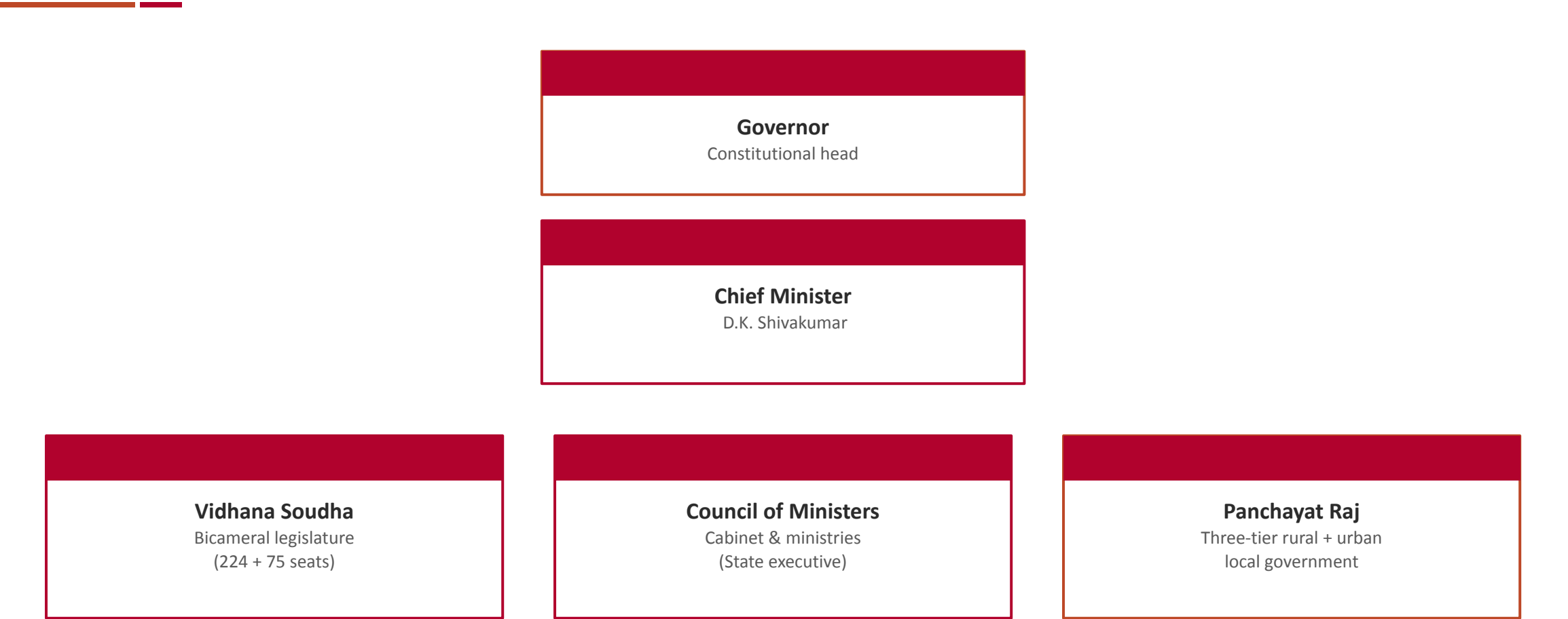
Child nutrition: 26.5% of children under five were stunted in Karnataka in NFHS-6 (2023–24). This indicates that more than one in four children under five were affected by stunting.

Education

- **School attendance:** 77.8% of females aged 6+ had ever attended school, up from 73.0% in NFHS-5.
- **Women's educational attainment:** 57.6% of women aged 15–49 had 10+ years of schooling, compared with 50.2% earlier.
- **Men's educational attainment:** 63.0% of men aged 15–49 had 10+ years of schooling, up from 56.5%.
- **Pre-school participation:** 50.7% of children aged 2–4 were attending pre-school, compared with 44.5% in NFHS-5.
- **Women's digital access:** Internet use among women aged 15–49 increased sharply from 35.0% to **57.9%**.
- **Men's digital access:** Internet use among men aged 15–49 increased from 56.3% to **84.3%**.

Key takeaway: Karnataka shows improvement in both **educational attainment and digital access**, but a **gender gap in internet use and educational attainment remains**.

The Current Governance Structure



Judiciary

Supreme Court

High Court
(Attara Kacheri)

District Court
(Civil)

Additional Benches
Hubballi-Dharwad and Kalaburagi

Sessions Court
(Criminal)

Governance Fault Lines

- Sidda–DKS friction : the dual-leadership arrangement breeds succession rivalry.
- Coalition management : JD(S) & independent MLAs as swing factors.
- Bureaucratic capacity vs the scale of welfare delivery (DBT, Seva Sindhu).
- Centre–state tension : devolution, GST and flagship-scheme contestation.
- Regional imbalance : north Karnataka's persistent grievance over neglect.

What India can learn from Karnataka

Welfare at scale

- the five guarantees show both the electoral payoff and the fiscal cost of universal entitlements.

Caste data & social justice

- the survey opens a national conversation on evidence-based reservation.

Regional federalism

- Karnataka's six-region structure is a model of managing intra-state diversity.

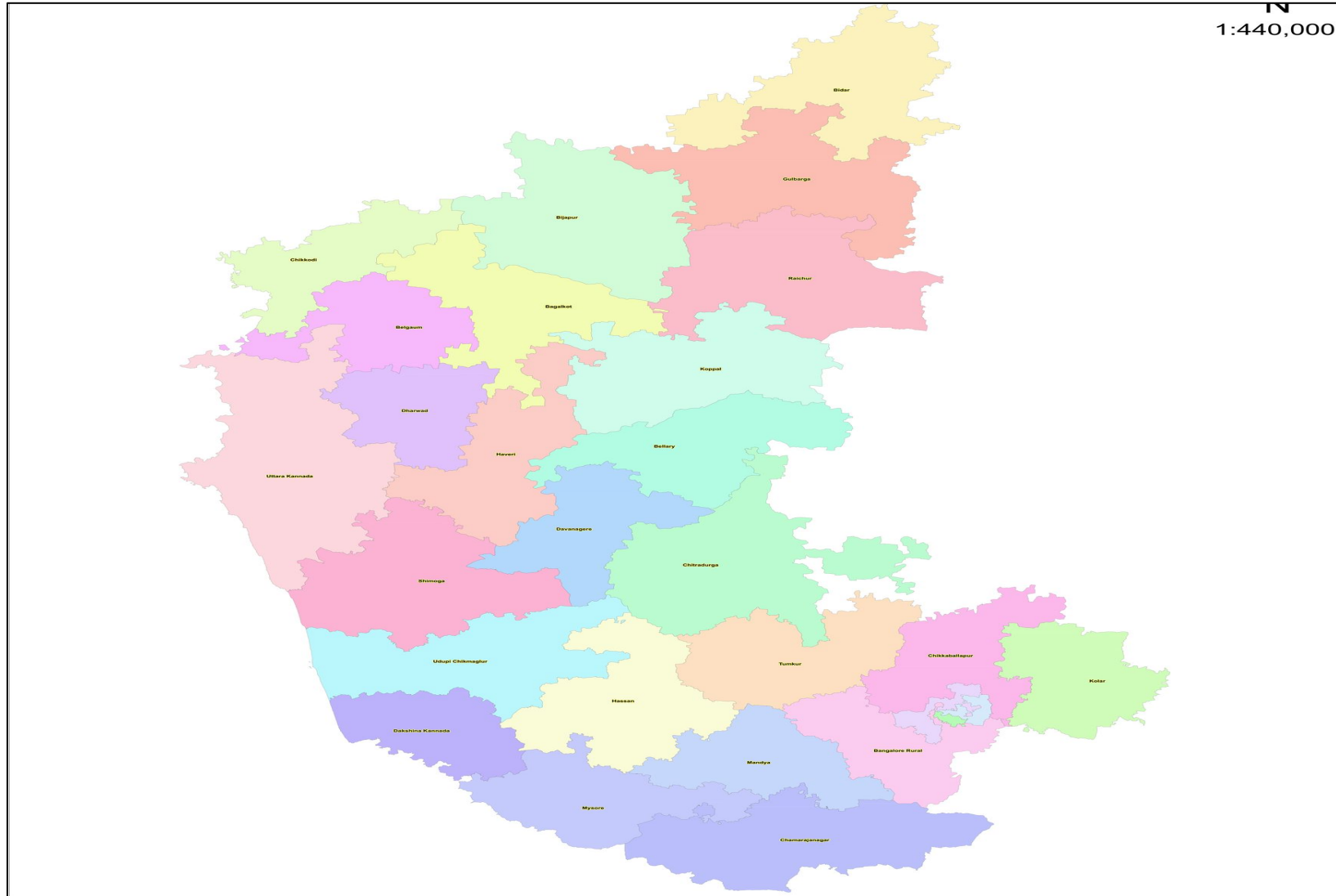
Dual leadership

- balancing caste blocs via a CM–Dy CM formula, and its risks.

Bengaluru Model

- over burdened civic infra supporting start up capital.

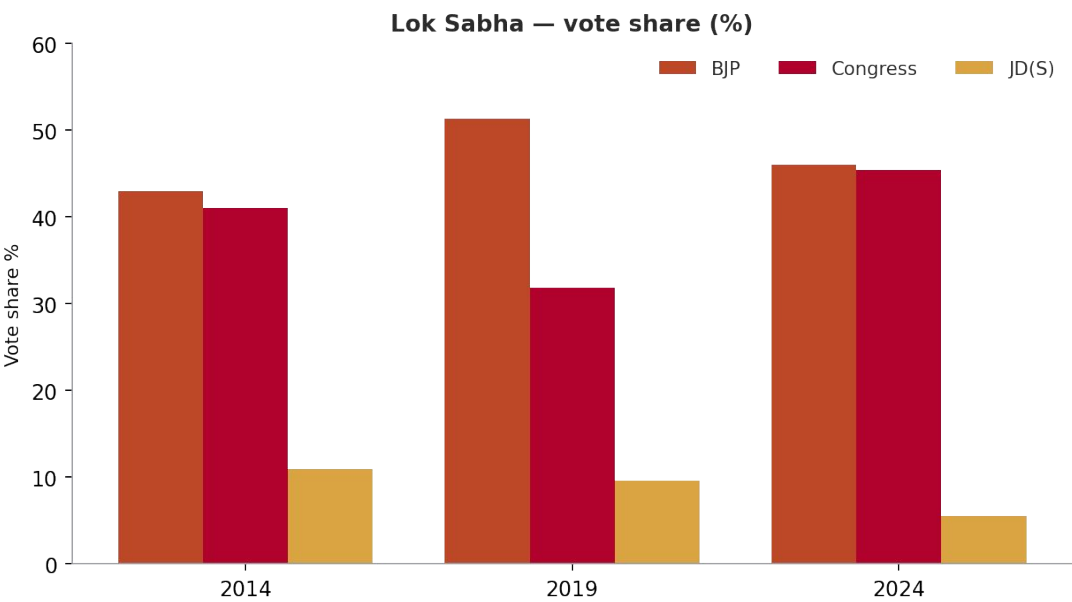
Lok Sabha Seats



Last 3 Lok Sabhas : % of votes

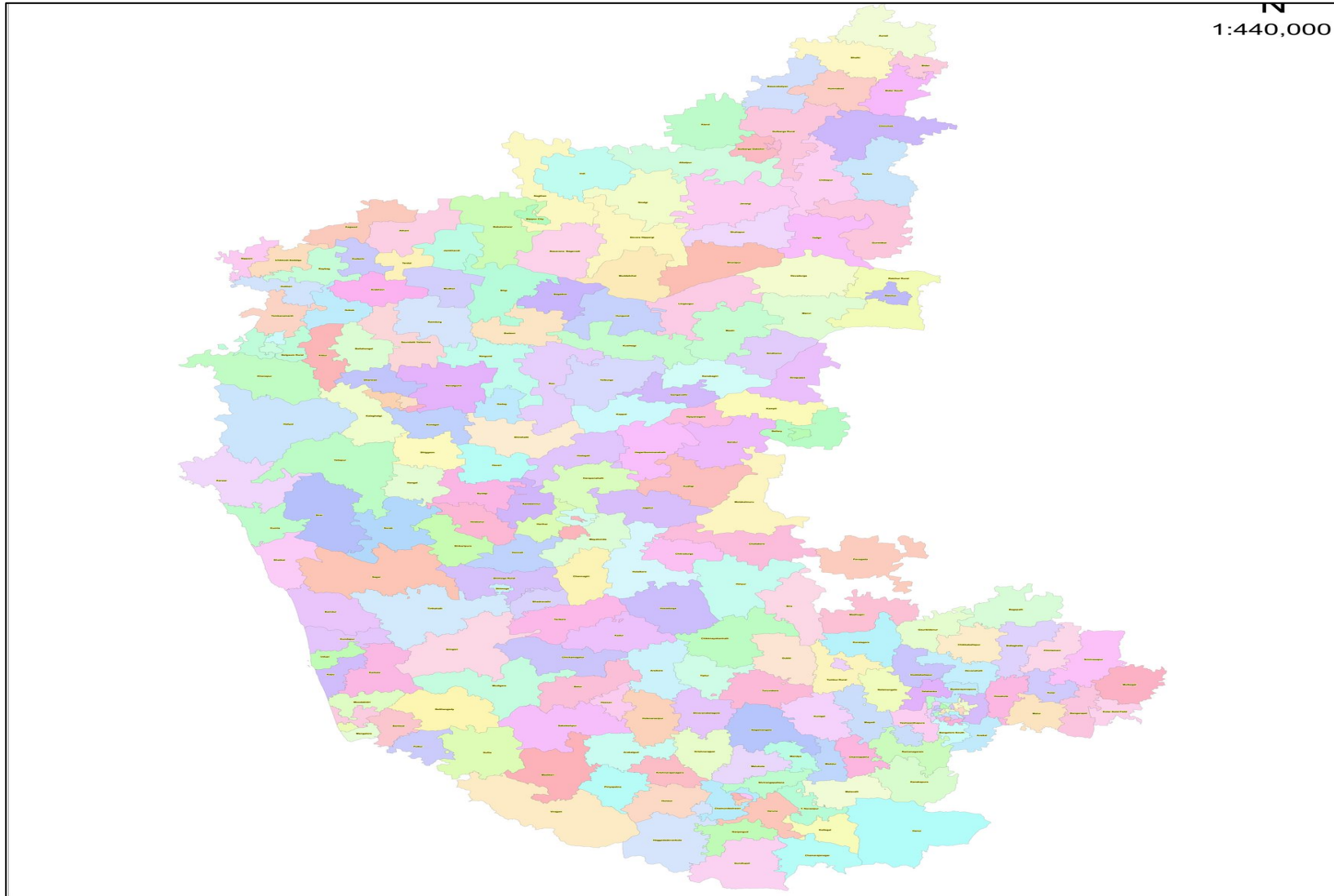
Party	2014	2019	2024
BJP	17 · 43.0%	25 · 51.4%	17 · 46.1%
Congress	9 · 40.8%	1 · 31.9%	9 · 45.4%
JD(S)	2 · 11.0%	1 · 9.7%	2 · 5.6%

Others / Ind. 0 1 (Ind.) 0



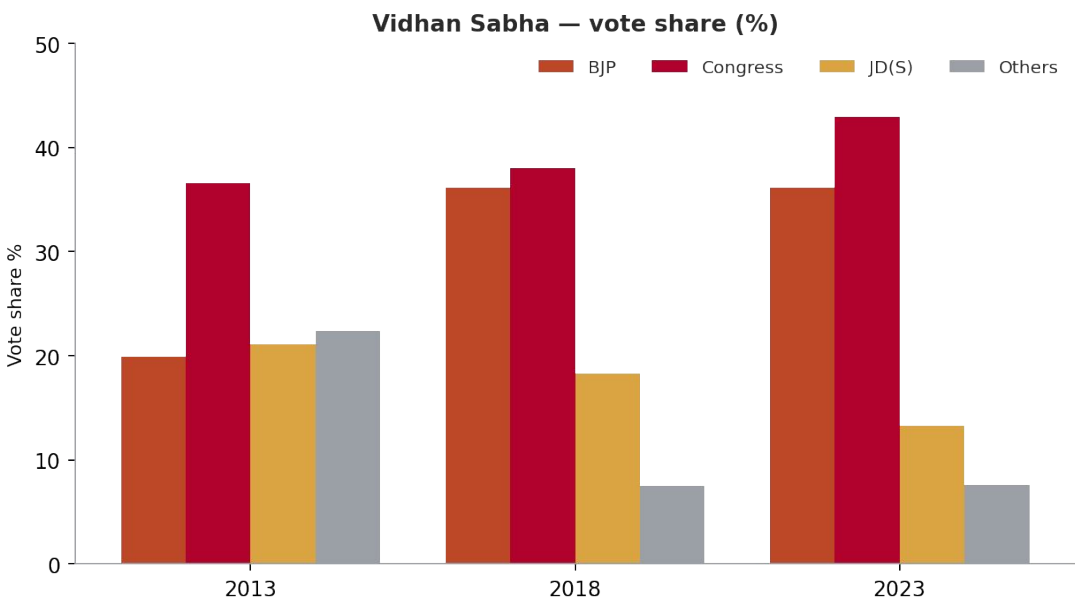
Seats won · vote share (%). Source: Election Commission of India. 2019 'Others' = Sumalatha (Ind., Mandya, BJP-backed).

Vidhan Sabha Seats



Last 3 Vidhan Sabhas : % of votes

Party	2013	2018	2023
Congress	122 · 36.6%	80 · 39.0%	135 · 42.9%
BJP	40 · 19.9%	104 · 36.2%	66 · 36.2%
JD(S)	40 · 21.1%	37 · 18.3%	19 · 13.3%
Others	22 · 22.4%	5 · 7.5%	4 · 7.6%



Seats won · vote share (%). Source: Election Commission of India. 2013 'Others' includes Yediyurappa's KJP & BSR Congress.

Similarities & divergence

Similarities

- All three parties now run welfare heavy campaigns and court Lingayat & Vokkaliga blocs.
- All converge on caste-coalition engineering despite different ideological labels.

Divergence

- Congress : AHINDA (minorities-backward-Dalit) + urban secular pitch.
- BJP : Lingayat + Hindutva + urban middle class; strongest on the coast & cities.
- JD(S) : Vokkaliga agrarian base of the Deve Gowda family; kingmaker niche.

The eve of the 2028 Vidhan Sabha

- Incumbency test : Can Congress convert its 2023 sweep into re-election against anti-incumbency?
- BJP–JD(S) alliance : A consolidated challenger now, reversing the 2024 Lok Sabha split.
- The guarantee bill : Fiscal stress vs the schemes' popularity among women & youth.
- Caste-survey fallout : Reservation politics could realign the Lingayat/Vokkaliga vote.
- Swing regions : Kalyana Karnataka (Congress), Coastal & Bengaluru (BJP), Old Mysore (three-way).

Concluding remarks

Karnataka is best read region by region, six overlapping Society–Polity–Economy zones, not one monolith.

Its politics is a long inheritance: dynasty, unification and caste coalitions still set today's battlegrounds.

The 2023 mandate was a bet on welfare; its fiscal bill is now the central question.

Heading into 2028, the fights are over entitlements, caste data and the region-by-region swing vote.

Thank you!

